

Method and Insight

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Method and Insight

R. W. Hepburn

Fr. Bernard Lonergan's writings have not so far received much discussion in British philosophical journals, although they contain one of the most fully-developed contemporary presentations of Catholic Christianity and have a substantial and distinctive philosophical content. They have not lacked theological commentators, both in print and in conference-discussions. The present article has three aims: to draw attention to Lonergan's work and its philosophical relevance; to notice the publication of his latest book, *Method in Theology*, and to venture some critical comments on certain arguments about the intelligibility of being, being and the good, and God, in his book *Insight* (published first in 1957).¹ These arguments are central to Lonergan's account of theism, a theism which, in its orthodox Roman Catholic form, is presupposed by *Method in Theology*. The books are organically interrelated. One admirer of Lonergan described the newer book (before its appearance) as 'the book [Lonergan] originally set out to write'.²

A study in methodology could hardly be seen as crowning a writer's achievement, unless that methodology amounted to more than merely formal architectonic. Lonergan's *Method in Theology*³ is certainly more than that. For instance, the divisions of the subject, the 'functional specialties' into which Lonergan divides the tasks of theology, closely relate to his philosophical analysis of the mind's activities in general. Although the work as a whole will be primarily of interest to the theologian, the earlier chapters seek to provide an unusually broad foundation for his operations ('Method', 'The Human Good', 'Meaning').

Transcendental method is evident from the start of the work. Lonergan will not discuss theology without first enquiring into the 'dynamic structure of . . . cognitional and moral being'. To discover that is to discover something 'not open to radical revision' because it is the 'condition of the possibility of any revision' (*MT* xii). Lonergan distinguishes four 'levels of consciousness and intentionality'—the 'empirical', 'intellectual' (enquiry, understanding), the 'rational' (considered as the judging of truth and falsity), the 'responsible' (concern with goals and action). He claims further that this four-fold transcendental analysis yields precepts capable of

¹ I shall quote from the Third Edition, 1970: now published in Britain by Darton, Longman and Todd, London: pp. xxx + 784. £4.00.

² Conn O'Donovan, in *Clergy Review*, 1969, p. 678.

³ Darton, Longman and Todd, London, 1971, pp. xii + 405. £4.50.

pointing the way to social progress, and of diagnosing social decline through their neglect. Cryptically: 'Be attentive, Be intelligent, Be reasonable, Be responsible'. Disregard of these 'transcendental precepts' is the 'basic form of alienation' (*MT* 9, 52–55). To call the structure 'dynamic' is to say, *inter alia*, that there is a *nisus* away from mere immediacy of experience towards understanding; and a 'striving for a richer apprehension of . . . [the yet] incompletely known totality' (ultimately the universe as such).

'Self-transcendence' is involved in these operations, and Chapter 2 on 'The Human Good' develops the theme: ' . . . as the transcendental notions of the intelligible, the true, the real head for a complete intelligibility . . . so the transcendental notion of the good heads for a goodness that is beyond criticism' (*MT* 36). Lonergan's picture of human possibility and development is hierarchical as well as dynamic: 'at the summit of the ascent from the initial infantile bundle of needs . . . and gratifications, there are to be found the deep-set joy . . . the power and the vigor, of being in love with God' (*MT* 39).

Chapter 3 studies 'meaning' in a very wide sense of the word. It includes non-linguistic meaning, aesthetic meaning (to which Susanne Langer is the guide), symbols and their interpretation (from Freud to Northrop Frye), linguistic meaning, and 'incarnate meaning' (the 'meaning' of a way of life, or of a person). Various 'realms of meaning' are distinguished and once more treated with dynamic and developmental emphasis. The commonsense realm comes to be known by a 'self-correcting process of learning' (*MT* 81): beyond it is the realm of theory, dealing with questions that commonsense cannot answer: beyond again are 'interiority and subjectivity—self-appropriation', awareness of one's conscious activity on the four levels distinguished. Finally there is 'transcendent exigence'—again the unrestricted demand for intelligibility, the criticism of every finite good (*MT* 83f), and the relating of subject to deity through the language of prayer. 'Man's transcendental subjectivity is mutilated or abolished, unless he is stretching forth towards the intelligible, the unconditioned, the good' (Chapter 4 : 1, 'The Question about God'). Even the atheist, declaring the region of the divine to be empty, cannot help presupposing 'our native orientation to the divine'.

More specifically on the practice of theology, Lonergan proposes that the tasks of theology are best displayed by an eight-fold analysis in terms of 'functional specialties' or 'specializations' (Chapter 5). These are (1) 'research', furnishing basic data; (2) 'interpretation', seeking to understand the data; (3) 'history', particularly the history of Christian doctrine and the cultural and institutional history relating to it; (4) 'dialectic', working towards a 'comprehensive viewpoint' amongst conflicting theological movements and positions; (5) 'foundations', the understanding and 'objectifying' of the conversion that is 'basic to Christian living'; (6) 'doc-

trines', the study of, *e.g.*, dogmatic, moral and pastoral theology; (7) 'systematics', aiming at conceptual coherence among doctrines, and striving 'for some inkling of how it could possibly be that the facts are what they are' (*MT* 336); (8) 'communications', religion speaking to 'all cultures and classes'. Lonergan explicitly connects this scheme with the four-fold account of 'our conscious and intentional operations', and stresses the interdependence of the specializations.

Successive chapters develop each of the eight themes, chapters too rich in material to allow fair summary. The chapters on history, for instance, summarize and comment upon a wide range of theories of historical study. Chapter 10, on Dialectic, includes a short statement of Lonergan's 'critical realism'. Knowing is not like looking: to suppose that it is ignores the difference between the infant's world of immediacy, and the world 'mediated by meaning'—the field of understanding and judgment. Critical realism steers between empiricism and idealism, by considering the activity of 'experiencing, understanding and judging' as a 'process of self-transcendence'. Objective knowledge is not properly to be restricted to sense-experience; nor is the world mediated by meaning an ideal construction only (*MT* 238f).

Lonergan sees religious conversion as also a mode of self-transcendence (*MT* 241). It is 'a fundamental . . . change in the human reality that a theologian is' (*MT* 270).

To understand how the development of doctrine (Chapter 12) is possible, Lonergan argues, we need a fuller account of the 'differentiations of consciousness'. This is supplied under a variety of headings: the learning-processes of commonsense, various recognitions of transcendence, the emergence of 'systematic meaning' and the constructing of technical languages for special studies, the impact of the special studies back upon commonsense, the attainment of self-consciousness about methods of enquiry and the revisability of conclusions, the acquiring of scholarly skills and the exploration of 'interiority' itself (*MT* 302–5). Individually and culturally, these are stages in the 'ongoing discovery of mind', a process that, through successive transformations of the context in which a religious doctrine is formulated, necessitates a transformation in the doctrine itself.

The chapter on 'Systematics' contains, among other philosophically relevant material, a discussion on the question, 'Is God an object?'. Lonergan denies that God is an object in the sense of something 'already out there' or 'up there' or 'in here now'. When we speak of God in the primary sense of the word, we are speaking of what lies beyond 'the world mediated by meaning'—of an 'orientation to transcendent mystery'. Nevertheless, he allows that (on another level) we may ask questions like 'Could the world's facticity be reconciled with its intelligibility, if it did not have an intelligible ground?', and that we can arrive at an assurance

that there is indeed a necessary ground of the universe. Intentionality is fundamental: 'God becomes an object in the very precise sense of what is intended in questions and known by correct answers'. A consequence of the shift to 'intentionality analysis' is that theological terms will cease to be metaphysical and become psychological (*MT* 343).

Lonerger's major works virtually defy review: not only because of their enormous range of topics and of the many special fields from which material and illustrations are drawn, but also because of their great density of argument, much of it expressed already as summarily as is possible without loss of intelligibility. The only course open is drastically to select and take note of what seem to be landmarks in the unfolding of his thought: but of course with a troubled conscience over the risks of distortion this must bring.

I begin my own comments with a few very minor points on Chapter 3. This chapter, on meaning, deploys rapidly a particularly large range of data, none of it irrelevant: but the effect in places is uncomfortably breathless. The brief treatment of aesthetic meaning is rather one-sided, drawing on Mrs Langer's writings without taking account of her critics. The section on 'symbols' is over-allusive and compressed. Here and there Lonergan's style is less felicitous than usual. Metaphors sometimes get out of control: Parmenides' achievement, *e.g.*, 'provided a carrier for a breakthrough' (*MT* 91); logic and science emerged 'on a rising tide of linguistic feedback' (*MT* 97). But this is far from typical of Lonergan's writing.

To look forward to a substantial matter which I wish to discuss with reference to *Insight* as well as *Method in Theology*: Lonergan eloquently describes our various *reachings-out* towards a transcendent, our 'orientation to the divine'. Now there is a gap between this intentional, dynamic presentation, with its heuristic or regulative employment of the key notions, and (on the other side) an affirmation that the divine exists in itself, independent of all our aspirings and self-transcendings. I can accept a great part of the former, regulative account, and do accept it, without a commitment to the latter. For all his emphasis on the epistemological and intentional, and his readiness to see theological terms shift from a metaphysical to a psychological rôle, Lonergan is not content to ascribe to God the status of an intentional entity only. The reference to an argument for God as the ground of being makes that clear enough; but it is implied on every page. Yet, to go beyond the intentional and regulative, we have to resort to irreducibly metaphysical argument.

A theologian who took Lonergan's map of theology as his guide would certainly work with a good sense of the complexity of his enterprise, and a healthy sense of the interconnections between theology and secular disciplines. I am not sure whether he would be equally well equipped to discriminate dispassionately between well-founded and ill-founded systems of belief—supposing that to be possible. 'It is the religious conversion that

grounds both moral and intellectual conversion . . . it provides the real criterion by which all else is to be judged' (*MT* 283). Since Lonergan's statement of the methodology presupposes and uses Christian beliefs and concepts, the method can hardly function as a direct means of appraising the issues between theism and scepticism. Nevertheless, Lonergan could justifiably reply to this remark, and to the point made in the previous paragraph, that he had treated of these issues at length in *Insight*, where an elaborately wrought argument for theism is the culmination of his study of human understanding. Let us turn briefly to that argument.

Insight claims that knowledge of the world is not a matter of passively receiving empirical data, but is the discerning of intelligible structure and unity in the data. There are hierarchically-ordered levels of knowing; what is anomalous and coincidental at one level may become rationally graspable on the next. Linking this scheme to the understanding of *development* and *emergence*, Lonergan writes:

. . . chemical elements and compounds are higher integrations of otherwise coincidental manifolds of subatomic events; organisms are higher integrations of otherwise coincidental manifolds of chemical processes, sensitive consciousness is a higher integration of otherwise coincidental manifolds of changes in neural tissues; and accumulating insights are higher integrations of otherwise coincidental manifolds of images or of data—*Insight* 451.

So basic to Lonergan is the dynamic and unrestricted character of the human urge to know that he defines 'being' indirectly as 'the objective of the pure desire to know' (*I* 348). To *understand* being would require an 'unrestricted act of understanding' (*I* 648), an act we cannot perform. We can affirm, however, that being is intelligible, 'to be known by the totality of true judgments' (*I* 350). 'Being, then, is intelligible, for it is what is to be known by correct understanding; and it is completely intelligible, for being is known completely only when all intelligent questions are answered correctly' (*I* 673). But surely there may exist an 'unknowable'? To say Yes to that would be incoherent, 'for then one would be knowing that the unknowable is' (*I* 352). Now being that is intelligible cannot 'be or exist or occur merely as a matter of fact for which no explanation is to be asked or expected, for the non-intelligible is apart from being' (*I* 656). But the world of our experience is 'shot through with contingency'. We must therefore posit an ultimate non-contingent ground for the universe. Lonergan argues that such a ground will be neither necessitated nor arbitrary, and that the universe proceeds from 'the reasonable choice of a rational consciousness' (*I* 656f). The thrust of his reasoning culminates in an affirmation of deity as making that 'unrestricted act of understanding' which is both an act of self-understanding, and, through that, of understanding all else.

I have sampled rather than condensed Lonergan's many-stranded

arguments. There is no question about the claim that bears the greatest weight in the structure; it is the assertion that being is intelligible. Explicitly Lonergan states that common to all arguments for God's existence is the pattern:—'If the real is completely intelligible, God exists. But the real is completely intelligible . . .' (I 672). Has Lonergan in fact shown that being is intelligible in this thoroughgoing way?

He has certainly shown how shifts from 'lower' to 'higher' viewpoints (for instance, in science) can disclose intelligibility in what was chaotic from the lower viewpoint. But I am not convinced that this is, and must be, true for all being. We can admit that our desire to know is 'unrestricted', and that a confidence in our finding ever more intelligible structure as the range of our enquiry is continuously extended, is heuristically of the greatest value. I doubt, however, whether the gap has been closed between the expression of such a confidence or hope and the very strong claim that being is intelligible through and through. No transcendental argument is likely to close it, for our intellectual activities and achievements would be possible in a universe with a limited intelligibility only. Doubtless there would be contradiction in claiming to know an unknowable, but there seems no contradiction in saying that not all there is may be knowable; that is to say, that some data may elude or resist intelligible explanation, no matter to what level or viewpoint the matter is pursued.

As we have seen, there are statements of the thesis 'being is intelligible' in which Lonergan presents it as definitional and stipulative in form. '... one defines being by its intelligibility'. One 'implies that being is known completely when there are no further questions to be answered' (I 499, cf. 348). If it is against *that* background that one asserts 'being is what is to be known by intelligence, and so it must be intelligible', one says what is necessarily but uninformatively true.

The source of the difficulty, I think, is Lonergan's aim to give primacy to the epistemological and yet to derive far-reaching ontological conclusions from his enquiry. My uneasiness about the argument occurs precisely at the point of transition from the epistemological claim, about the desire and quest for intelligibility, to the ontological claim that reality must be such as to satisfy these, not only in fact but limitlessly in principle.

If one begins by stipulating the thoroughgoing intelligibility of being, one thereby commits oneself to look for ways of overcoming the obvious *prima facie* counter-evidence to the claim, the existence of areas of experience where we confront *incomplete* intelligibility. If one is not so committed—because one has not first affirmed the intelligibility of being—the counter-evidence may well make one doubt whether the claim can reasonably be made. In fact, Lonergan's argument to God is the argument that God's existence is demanded by what I am calling the counter-evidence, taken together with the premise that being is indeed and nevertheless intelligible. Lonergan, close to St Thomas, takes the contingency of the

universe of our experience and (among several other things) the regress of causal dependence, to imply that the world of our experience is incompletely intelligible. Add to that the premise that being as such is completely intelligible, and the existence of a transcendent God can be inferred (*I* 678). My difficulty, however, is that one might equally well take our insights into 'incomplete intelligibility' as considerations against affirming the complete intelligibility of being in the first place; and thus deprive the argument of a vital premise. Lonergan would retort: 'Mere matters of fact cannot be ultimate for intelligence' (*I* 678). Reference to matters of fact cannot, I agree, be 'ultimate' in that sense: but once again the lack of such ultimacy need not thwart or sabotage our efforts to understand what *can* be understood.

Logically parallel difficulties attend also Lonergan's identification of being with goodness. 'As being is intelligible and one, so also it is good' (*I* 596); '... it should be possible to ... conceive the good as identical with the intelligibility which is intrinsic to being' (*I* 604). But what now of evil? I confine the issue, for reasons of space, to the question of *physical* evil. As before, it is possible to see ways of preventing the existence of physical evil from defeating a *prior commitment* to the proposition 'Being is good'. 'There are false starts, break-downs, failures; advance is at the price of risk' (*I* 667). Crucially, 'the imperfection of the lower is the potentiality for the higher'. In general, to will the order of the universe is not '... to demand that all things be perfect in their inception but to expect and will that they grow and develop' (*I* 699). If, however, one considers *first of all* the pain, the waste, the dead-ends and delays of evolutionary processes, while not at all denying that a measure of intelligible order can also be discerned in the processes, one may well be held back from the comprehensive claim that being-as-such and the good-as-such can be identified. The problem is to find warrant for passing from the limited to the unlimited claim.

Whatever misgivings I have about the ontological side of Lonergan's thought, I am more confident that there is a good deal to be learned from the epistemological side. Lonergan's 'critical realism' is impressively defended, both against an empiricism that fails 'to note all the structuring elements that are constitutive of human knowing yet are not given to sense', and against idealism which forgets that 'intellectual and rational operations involve a transcendence of the ... subject' (*MT* 76). Lonergan's hierarchical and dynamic account of insight or understanding does introduce a large amount of intelligible order into the subject-matter of epistemology, an order not so likely to be disclosed to minute and piecemeal analysis alone. The vast scale of Lonergan's writing, particularly in *Insight*, is understandable, if daunting, given this synoptic aim.

No doubt there are places in *Insight* and *Method in Theology* where a reader would welcome a release from the systematic, remorseless, leave-

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no-topic-untreated style, and wishes for a philosophy of the illuminating paradox, the aphorism, the arresting but not fully-analysed metaphor. Yet it must be acknowledged, in honesty, that when commenting on writings in the latter style, one is often moved to say: 'This is thought-provoking and imaginative; but before we can really judge its adequacy it will need to be worked out in much greater detail'. It is certainly not to Lonergan's discredit that he does seek to work out his main ideas in detail, hard though this is on his non-polymathic readers.

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